

Confirming Process, Missing Function.

The uninstrumented oversight layer in AI transparency and control research.



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Two states, one record.

The contrast that matters is obscured in the audit trail.

SAMPLE	
LANE A	AX-4471 · reviewer #214
 	
ENGAGED · EXAMINED OUTPUT	
REVIEWED	14 : 32 : 07
DECISION	14 : 50 : 14 (+18 min)
DOCUMENTATION	4 of 4 fields
✓ COMPLIANT	

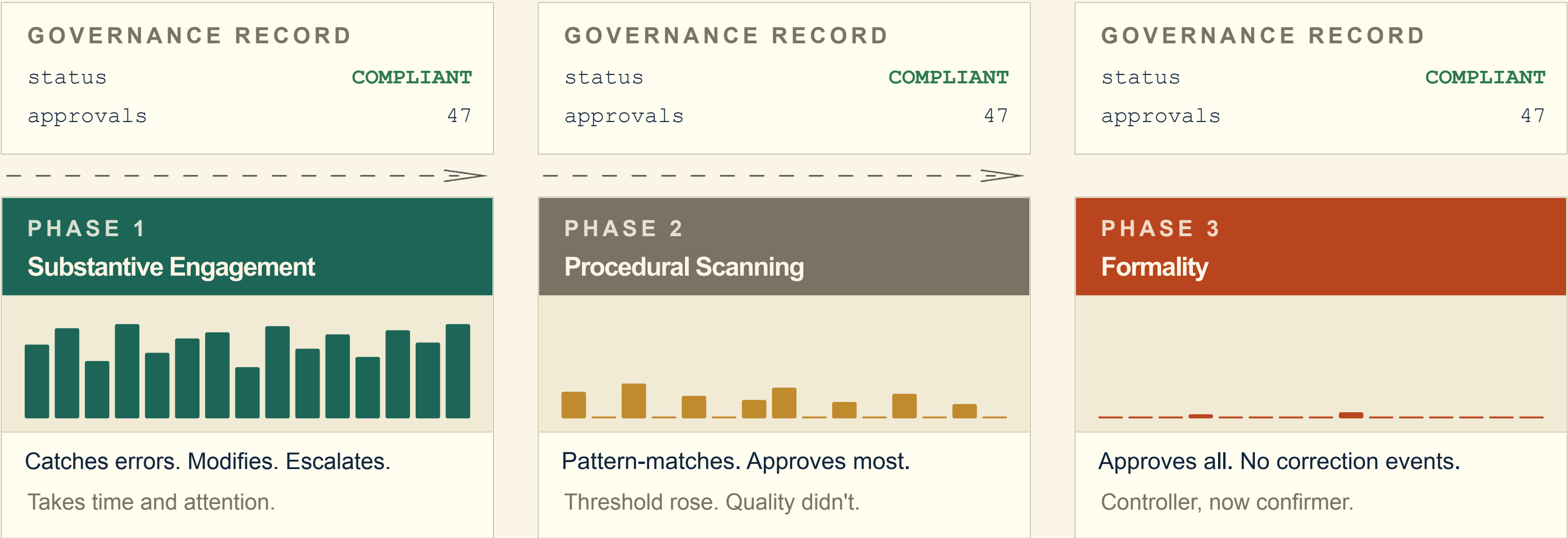
SAMPLE	
LANE B	AX-4471 · reviewer #338
 	
NOT ENGAGED · CLICKED THROUGH	
REVIEWED	14 : 32 : 07
DECISION	14 : 32 : 13 (+6 sec)
DOCUMENTATION	4 of 4 fields
✓ COMPLIANT	

One review took **eighteen minutes** of substantive evaluation. One took **six seconds** of procedural confirmation. The audit record does not distinguish them.

Three claims hold up the paper.

1. The oversight function is a **system component** , not a binary switch.
2. It degrades predictably under operational conditions. The degraded state and the functional state leave **identical governance traces**.
3. Current detection, interpretability, and governance methods do not close the gap, because they **instrument the wrong layer** .

Behavior degrades. The record stays uniform.



Same status. Same approval count. Same record.

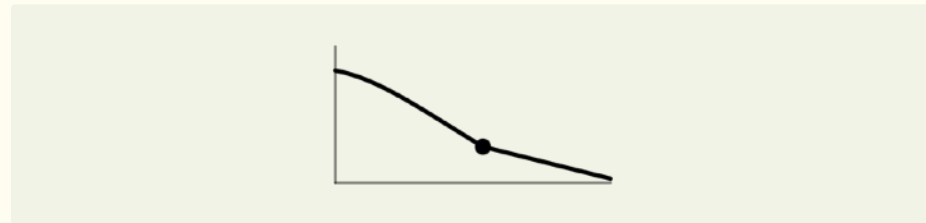
The audit log does not capture the signal the behavioral channel is losing.

Model-centric vs. oversight-centric transparency.

	TODAY Model-centric	PROPOSED Oversight-centric
OBJECT INSTRUMENTED	Model reasoning, outputs, behavior	Functional state of the oversight mechanism
EVIDENCE PRODUCED	Interpretability maps, audit logs, governance artifacts	Engagement metrics, correction trajectories, calibration indicators
FAILURE MODE ADDRESSED	Hallucination, bias, distribution shift	Authority drift, procedural confirmation, oversight formality
HUMAN ROLE ASSUMED	Stable recipient of explanations	Degradable component requiring care and feeding

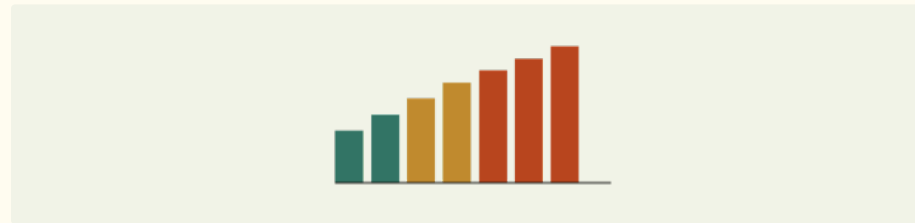
Detection, interpretability, and governance each compound the gap rather than closing it.

Three candidate proxies for engagement state.



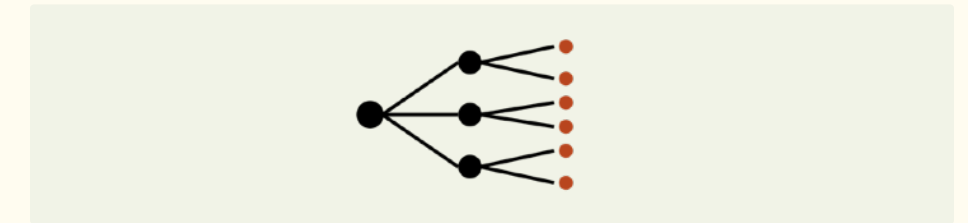
Correction trajectory

Reviewer engagement against output volume over deployment duration.



Validation load

Outputs requiring review per unit of reviewer capacity.



Dependency accumulation

Downstream workflow nodes depending on each approved output.

DESIGN PRINCIPLE

Satisfying the metric and exercising genuine oversight should be difficult to decouple.

Designed as workflow-level structural signals, not individual reviewer monitoring.

Five mechanisms practitioners can pilot today.

01



Seeded calibration checks

Pre-validated outputs injected into the queue. Disagreement rate on seeded items tracks engagement on the rest.

02



Onboarding-period baselines

Log new reviewers' correction patterns before calibration. Gaps signal that operational norms have drifted.

03



Dependency surfacing at decision time

Show the reviewer how many downstream things depend on this approval, at the moment of approval.

04



Decision-point logging for long-running workflows

Structured events at each irreversible decision in an agentic trajectory, not just the final output.

05



Workload ceilings with backpressure

Routing refuses additional outputs to a saturated reviewer. Converts an indicator into an enforcement mechanism.

All can be built with current workflow infrastructure and existing logging.

Three partnership types.

Shaped by experience teaching and working in enterprise deployments.

- **Deployment-context partners** instrument oversight quality in operational settings, under structural-and-aggregate constraints.
- **Regulatory and standards partners** work on making oversight requirements functionally rather than procedurally auditable.
- **Methodological partners** bring expertise on the cognitive dynamics of evaluative judgment under fluent-text review.

Process compliance was the right thing to measure when the risk was non-compliance. It is not the right thing to measure when the risk is procedural compliance coexisting with functional absence.

SCAN TO FOLLOW UP



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